

Vocabulary: Stonewall riots

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In 1969, New York police raided the Stonewall Inn, a gay bar in Manhattan. This wasn't unusual, as gay bars were often raided in the 1960s. When that happened, people didn't usually oppose resistance, but this time was different. Customers at Stonewall Inn fought back as hard as they could to avoid being arrested. Soon, they were joined by people outside the bar who started attacking police.

The riots continued for several days and attracted a lot of media attention. As a result, they soon snowballed into a much bigger movement. The Stonewall raid triggered huge protests in New York and all over the United States. Gay people showed their anger by demonstrating in the streets to denounce police violence. They wanted to show the world that they were fed up with violence against the gay community, and that they wanted it to stop. They couldn't remain silent any longer - they had to speak out and make their voices heard. They would be 'out, loud and proud'!

The Stonewall riots brought the gay community a lot of visibility in the US and made people aware of the discrimination they faced. Americans realised that it was unfair to treat gays differently because of their sexuality. Before then, the gay community had been pessimistic about the future and didn't think their situation could improve, but now they felt hopeful and confident that they could change things for the better.

For a long time, the NYPD remained unyielding in their attitude to the Stonewall riots and refused to condemn their attack on the bar. However, in 2019, 50 years after the events, the NYPD police chief apologised to the gay community and said he regretted what had happened at Stonewall.

Match the underlined words in the text with their definition.

1. _____ : believing that something you want will happen, optimistic
2. _____ : expecting that bad things will happen in the future
3. _____ : annoyed or bored, wanting something to change
4. _____ : determined, unlikely to change
5. _____ : not right or fair, not treating people equally
6. _____ : strongly criticise somebody or something
7. _____ : to resist strongly or attack somebody who has attacked you
8. _____ : to grow more important
9. _____ : to make oneself heard, share one's opinions publicly
10. _____ : to protest publicly by marching in the streets
11. _____ : to inform people of something
12. _____ : to make something happen suddenly, set off
13. _____ : to say that you are sorry for doing something wrong

Complete the sentences with an underlined word from the text.

1. Harvey Milk was the first openly gay politician to be elected in California. His election made young gay people _____ about their future.
2. Even though there's been a lot of progress on gay rights, there is still a lot of discrimination today, making the community feel _____ about being truly accepted.
3. If you're _____ homophobia and want it to stop, you should take part in a Pride march to _____ it.
4. It's good to have strong opinions, but that doesn't mean you have to be selfish and _____. Sometimes it's also good to change your mind!
5. Refusing to hire someone only because they're gay isn't just _____ and discriminatory, it's also illegal.
6. Nowadays, gay people are less afraid of _____ about their experience than before, when they had to stay 'in the closet' and hide their identity.
7. After the Stonewall riots, people started _____ in many US cities to protest against discrimination and _____ against police violence.
8. Social media are a great way to _____ of gay rights issues. You can reach a large audience and _____ a change in mentalities thanks to your actions.
9. If you offend someone by accident, the right thing to do is to _____.
10. The history of the Stonewall riots shows how a local protest can _____ into a much bigger movement.